Cultists

Doomsayers and Fanatics

Habitat: Any; **Treasure:** Individual, Relics

Cultists use magic and extreme measures to spread radical beliefs. Some privately pursue esoteric secrets, while others form shadowy cabals seeking to bring about terrifying ends. Cultists often follow obscure mystical traditions or obsess over interpretations of ancient prophecies. They might worship supernatural patrons—deities, otherworldly creatures, manipulative alien minds, or stranger forces. Roll on or choose a result from the Cultist Agendas table to inspire what a cultist seeks to achieve.

Cultist Agendas

1d6	The Cultist Strives To ...
1	Bring about the end of a dominant order, an age, or the world.
2	Burn away the comfortable lies of reality, revealing forgotten or terrible truths.
3	Expand their faith though mind control or supernatural coercion.
4	Make global changes, like sinking the land or awakening volcanoes.
5	Remake life on a mass scale, altering other creatures' bodies or spiritual beings.
6	Summon their deity or its herald, weapon, or realm into their world.

Occult Symbols

Cults often identify with symbols that exemplify their beliefs. Such symbols might mark objects important to the cult, as well as the dress and bodies of cultists themselves. These symbols might be broadly understandable, or they might have meaning only to cultists. Roll twice on or choose results from the Cult Symbols table to inspire a cult's icons.

Cult Symbols

1d10	The Symbol Is ...	Depicted As ...
1	An alchemical sign	A calendar or map
2	An animal	A crest or as heraldry
3	A celestial body	An elaborate diagram
4	A deity's icon	A metaphorical image
5	An element	A mystical being
6	An eye	Part of an equation
7	A geometric shape	A repeating pattern
8	A letter or number	A series of scratches
9	Part of a monster	A simple pictogram
10	A skull	A weapon or tool

Cult Members

Cults often form hierarchies around a charismatic or domineering leader. While cult members might work independently, they take their orders from superiors with greater supernatural powers. Any cult might have the following sorts of members.

Cultist

Cultists devote themselves to their faith's leaders and otherworldly masters. While this zeal grants cultists no magical powers, it gives them remarkable resolve in the face of threats. Cultists perform much of a cult's mundane work, which might include evangelism, criminal acts, or serving as sacrifices.

Cultist Fanatic

Cultist fanatics lead small cults or cells within larger cults. They're privy to more of a cult's mysteries than lower-ranking cultists are, granting them access to magical powers from their patrons.

Cultist Hierophant

Cultist hierophants are leaders who oversee the lives of their underlings, dictate the edicts of the cult, and interpret their patron's will. They possess supernatural powers gained from the cult's patron, supernatural sources, or the power of their own fanaticism. These leaders know their cult's deepest secrets and often control strange relics, mystical sites, and monstrous servants.

> Dread Tharizdun, power of the Elder Elemental Eye and master of all destructive forces, I am the Champion of Elemental Evil and am ready to carry out your wishes.
>
> —Rites of the Cult of Elemental Evil

Cultist

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

AC 12 **Initiative** +1 (11)
HP 9 (2d8)
Speed 30 ft.

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
Str	11	+0	+0	**Dex**	12	+1	+1	**Con**	10	+0	+0
Int	10	+0	+0	**Wis**	11	+0	+2	**Cha**	10	+0	+0

Skills Deception +2, Religion +2
Gear Leather Armor, Sickle
Senses Passive Perception 10
Languages Common
CR 1/8 (XP 25; PB +2)

Actions

Ritual Sickle. *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 3 (1d4 + 1) Slashing damage plus 1 Necrotic damage.

A DEATH CULTIST AND HIS FOLLOWERS SUMMON ORCUS, DEMON LORD OF UNDEATH.

AURORE FOLNY

CULTIST FANATIC

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

AC 13 **Initiative** +2 (12)
HP 44 (8d8 + 8)
Speed 30 ft.

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
STR	11	+0	+0	**DEX**	14	+2	+2	**CON**	12	+1	+1
INT	10	+0	+0	**WIS**	14	+2	+4	**CHA**	13	+1	+1

Skills Deception +3, Persuasion +3, Religion +2
Gear Holy Symbol, Leather Armor
Senses Passive Perception 12
Languages Common
CR 2 (XP 450; PB +2)

ACTIONS

Pact Blade. *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) Slashing damage plus 7 (2d6) Necrotic damage.

Spellcasting. The cultist casts one of the following spells, using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 12, +4 to hit with spell attacks):

At Will: *Light, Thaumaturgy*
2/Day: *Command*
1/Day: *Hold Person*

BONUS ACTIONS

Spiritual Weapon (2/Day). The cultist casts the *Spiritual Weapon* spell, using the same spellcasting ability as Spellcasting.

CULTIST HIEROPHANT

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

AC 16 **Initiative** +8 (18)
HP 144 (17d8 + 68)
Speed 30 ft.

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
STR	14	+2	+2	**DEX**	18	+4	+4	**CON**	18	+4	+4
INT	13	+1	+1	**WIS**	16	+3	+7	**CHA**	20	+5	+9

Skills Perception +7, Persuasion +9, Religion +5
Gear Breastplate, Holy Symbol
Senses Passive Perception 17
Languages Celestial, Common
CR 10 (XP 5,900; PB +4)

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The cultist makes three attacks, using Pact Blade or Radiant Ray in any combination.

Pact Blade. *Melee Attack Roll:* +9, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d6 + 5) Slashing damage plus 18 (4d8) Radiant damage.

Radiant Ray. *Ranged Attack Roll:* +9, range 120 ft. *Hit:* 31 (4d12 + 5) Radiant damage.

Spellcasting. The cultist casts one of the following spells, using Charisma as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 17):

At Will: *Mage Armor* (included in AC), *Thaumaturgy*
1/Day Each: *Jallarzi's Storm of Radiance* (level 7 version), *Mass Suggestion*

Types of Cultists

Cults can organize around any mystical tradition, but many serve supernatural beings. Cult members often have abilities tied to the forces they worship.

Aberrant Cultist

Aberrant cultists pursue mind-bending powers from alien forces. Aberrant cultists align with monsters such as aboleths and mind flayers or forces such as Cthulhu, Hadar, Ityak-Ortheel the Elf Eater, Nyarlathotep, malicious solar bodies, or entities from the Far Realm.

Death Cultist

Death cultists revel in nihilistic forces, embracing them as paths to undeath, multiversal purity, or entropic inevitability. These cultists serve powerful undead beings, apocalyptic prophecies, or immortals with power over death, such as Acererak, Kyuss, Orcus, Vecna, or Wee Jas.

Elemental Cultist

Elemental cultists harness destructive natural forces to cleanse the world of civilization or prove the dominance of one element over all others. Such cultists are aligned with Elemental monsters or wicked immortals such as the Princes of Elemental Evil or the Elder Elemental Eye.

Fiend Cultist

Fiend cultists worship fiends or evil deities. They often work to bring ruin to innocents or to summon their sinister patron into the world. Fiend cultists might serve infamous powers such as archdevils and demon lords, or foul immortals—beings such as Demogorgon, Pazuzu, Iuz, Zariel, or Zuggtmoy.

Aberrant Cultist

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral Evil

AC 14 **Initiative** +7 (17)
HP 137 (25d8 + 25)
Speed 30 ft.

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
Str	10	+0	+0	**Dex**	19	+4	+4	**Con**	12	+1	+1
Int	16	+3	+6	**Wis**	18	+4	+7	**Cha**	15	+2	+2

Skills Arcana +6, Perception +7, Religion +6
Senses Darkvision 90 ft.; Passive Perception 17
Languages Common, Deep Speech; telepathy 30 ft.
CR 8 (XP 3,900; PB +3)

Actions

Multiattack. The cultist makes two Tentacle Lash attacks. It can replace any attack with a use of Mind Rot.

Tentacle Lash. *Melee Attack Roll:* +7, reach 10 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d6 + 4) Slashing damage plus 14 (4d6) Psychic damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, it has the Grappled condition (escape DC 14) from one of two tentacles, and it has the Restrained condition until the grapple ends.

Mind Rot. *Wisdom Saving Throw:* DC 15, one creature the cultist can see within 90 feet. *Failure:* 27 (6d8) Psychic damage, and the target has the Poisoned condition until the start of the cultist's next turn. *Success:* Half damage only.

Spellcasting. The cultist casts one of the following spells, using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 15):

At Will: *Detect Thoughts, Minor Illusion*

Reactions

Counterspell (2/Day). The cultist casts *Counterspell* in response to that spell's trigger, using the same spellcasting ability as Spellcasting.

Death Cultist

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral Evil

AC 17 **Initiative** +4 (14)
HP 127 (15d8 + 60)
Speed 30 ft.

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
Str	19	+4	+4	**Dex**	12	+1	+1	**Con**	18	+4	+7
Int	12	+1	+1	**Wis**	16	+3	+6	**Cha**	14	+2	+2

Skills Insight +6, Perception +6, Religion +4
Gear Splint Armor
Senses Passive Perception 16
Languages Common
CR 8 (XP 3,900; PB +3)

Actions

Multiattack. The cultist makes three attacks, using Dread Scythe or Deathly Ray in any combination.

Dread Scythe. *Melee Attack Roll:* +7, reach 10 ft. *Hit:* 9 (1d10 + 4) Slashing damage plus 11 (2d10) Necrotic damage, and the target can't regain Hit Points until the end of its next turn.

Deathly Ray. *Ranged Attack Roll:* +6, range 120 ft. *Hit:* 22 (4d10) Necrotic damage.

Spellcasting. The cultist casts one of the following spells, using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 14):

At Will: *Speak with Dead, Thaumaturgy*

Bonus Actions

Spirit Wail (Recharge 5–6). *Wisdom Saving Throw:* DC 14, each creature in a 20-foot Emanation originating from the cultist. *Failure:* 14 (4d6) Psychic damage, and the creature has the Frightened condition until the end of its next turn. *Success:* Half damage only.

An aberrant cultist and an elemental cultist clash, unleashing the magic of their otherworldly patrons.

AURORE FOLNY

Elemental Cultist

Medium or Small Humanoid, Chaotic Evil

AC 16 **Initiative** +4 (14)
HP 135 (18d8 + 54)
Speed 30 ft.

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
Str	18	+4	+4	**Dex**	12	+1	+1	**Con**	16	+3	+6
Int	14	+2	+2	**Wis**	18	+4	+7	**Cha**	12	+1	+1

Skills Arcana +5, Perception +7, Religion +5
Gear Chain Mail
Senses Passive Perception 17
Languages Common, Primordial
CR 8 (XP 3,900; PB +3)

Actions

Multiattack. The cultist makes three attacks, using Elemental Flail or Elemental Claw in any combination.

Elemental Flail. *Melee Attack Roll:* +7, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 25 (6d6 + 4) damage of a type chosen by the cultist: Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder.

Elemental Claw. *Ranged Attack Roll:* +7, range 120 ft. *Hit:* 22 (4d10) damage of a type chosen by the cultist: Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder. If the target is a Medium or smaller creature, the cultist moves the target up to 10 feet straight toward or away from itself.

Spellcasting. The cultist casts one of the following spells, using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 15):

At Will: *Elementalism, Mage Hand*

Reactions

Elemental Absorption (1/Day). *Trigger:* The cultist takes Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, or Thunder damage. *Response:* The cultist gives itself Resistance to that instance of damage and gains 10 Temporary Hit Points.

Fiend Cultist

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral Evil

AC 16 **Initiative** +5 (15)
HP 127 (17d8 + 51)
Speed 30 ft.

		MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE			MOD	SAVE
Str	19	+4	+4	**Dex**	15	+2	+2	**Con**	16	+3	+6
Int	12	+1	+1	**Wis**	18	+4	+7	**Cha**	10	+0	+0

Skills Perception +7, Religion +4
Gear Breastplate
Senses Darkvision 90 ft. (unimpeded by magical Darkness); Passive Perception 17
Languages Abyssal, Common, Infernal
CR 8 (XP 3,900; PB +3)

Actions

Multiattack. The cultist makes three Pact Axe attacks.

Pact Axe. *Melee Attack Roll:* +7, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 10 (1d12 + 4) Slashing damage plus 13 (3d8) Fire damage.

Spellcasting. The cultist casts one of the following spells, using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 15, +7 to hit with spell attacks):

At Will: *Scorching Ray* (level 5 version), *Thaumaturgy*
2/Day: *Fireball* (level 6 version)

Reactions

Hellish Rebuke. The cultist casts *Hellish Rebuke* in response to that spell's trigger, using the same spellcasting ability as Spellcasting.